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Downy Woodpecker

Dryobates pubescens

QUICK STATS

Length	5.5 – 6.7 in (14 – 17 cm)
Wingspan	9.8 – 11.8 in (25 – 30 cm)
Weight	0.7 – 1.0 oz (20 – 33 g)
Lifespan	Up to 11 years (avg. 1–2 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Downy Woodpecker is the smallest woodpecker in North America and one of the most familiar visitors to backyard feeders across the continent. Despite its diminutive size, it is a bold and active bird, clinging to suet cages, sunflower feeders, and tree trunks with equal ease. Its crisp black-and-white plumage and the male's bright red nape patch make it easy to identify. The Downy is often confused with the larger Hairy Woodpecker, but can be distinguished by its much shorter bill relative to head size and its smaller overall dimensions. It is one of the most widespread woodpeckers in North America and a year-round resident throughout its range.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Downy Woodpecker inhabits a remarkable range of forested and semi-open environments across North America, from Alaska and northern Canada south through most of the United States, absent only from the arid Southwest and parts of the Great Plains. It thrives in deciduous and mixed forests, orchards, riparian corridors, suburban parks, and gardens with mature trees. Unlike many woodpeckers, it readily adapts to fragmented and urban habitats and is a common year-round feeder visitor across most of its range.

DIET & FEEDING

- Suet cakes — the single most effective food to offer
- Black-oil sunflower seeds and hulled chips
- Peanut butter (plain, no additives) smeared on bark
- Bark insects: beetle larvae, ants, moth cocoons
- Wild berries and plant galls in winter
- Poison ivy berries — an important winter food source

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Downy Woodpeckers are active, acrobatic birds that forage across a wide variety of surfaces — tree trunks, large branches, weed stems, and even corn stalks. Their small size allows them to exploit foraging niches unavailable to larger woodpeckers, including the tips of small branches and slender plant stems where insect eggs and larvae overwinter. Outside breeding season, Downies frequently join mixed-species foraging flocks with chickadees, nuthatches, and kinglets, benefiting from the collective vigilance of the group. Males and females partition foraging habitat even within a territory: males tend to forage on smaller branches and weed stems, females on larger trunks.

NESTING & BREEDING

Downy Woodpeckers excavate their own nest cavities in dead or dying trees, a process that takes both sexes 1–3 weeks to complete. The entrance hole is perfectly round, about 1.25 inches in diameter, leading to a gourd-shaped chamber 6–12 inches deep lined only with wood chips. No nest material is added. Clutches of 3–8 white eggs are incubated by both parents for 12 days. The male incubates at night. Nestlings are fed by both parents and fledge at 20–25 days. Old nest cavities are vital for other cavity-nesting species including chickadees, bluebirds, and small owls.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Downy Woodpecker's primary call is a sharp, flat "pik" — shorter and higher-pitched than the similar Hairy Woodpecker's call. It also produces a descending whinny call used during territorial interactions and a rattling "drum" — a rapid series of bill strikes on a resonant dead branch — used to establish territory and attract mates. Drumming rates average about 17 strikes per second. Both sexes drum, though males drum more frequently.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Stable
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The Downy Woodpecker population is estimated at over 14 million individuals and remains stable across its range. It benefits from dead tree retention in managed forests and suburban areas. Its excavated nest cavities provide essential housing for dozens of other cavity-dependent species, making it a keystone species in many woodland ecosystems.

FEEDER TIPS

- Suet cages are the most reliable way to attract Downy Woodpeckers
- Offer suet year-round — especially critical in cold winters
- Upside-down suet feeders deter starlings while Downies feed easily
- Hang feeders near tree trunks — Downies feel safer close to cover
- Leave dead trees standing when safe — essential for nesting and foraging

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Crown & back	<i>Solid black</i>
Wing spots	<i>Black with white dots/bars</i>
White back stripe	<i>Pure white center stripe</i>
Underparts	<i>White to pale buff</i>
Red nape patch (male)	<i>Bright red — rear of crown only</i>
Bill	<i>Short, dark gray, chisel-shaped</i>

COLOR ME!

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